

LevelUp

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(Don't Write
anything in this Area)

Q3. (a) Discuss the statement, "Culture is Superorganic". (15 marks)

E.B. Tylor, in PRIMITIVE CULTURE (1871) gave the evolutionary definition of culture as "a complex whole of knowledge, belief, customs, moral, art and law ACQUIRED by man as members of society".

The superorganic view of culture was propounded by Jessie White and Alfred Kroeber.

PREMISE

"Superorganic" refers to something that is above organic entities. Kroeber noted that culture can't be expressed as a function of any individual's behaviour. Rather, since culture is TRANSMISSIBLE and ADAPTIVE, it operates as per LAW of its own. i.e. culture is superindividual and superorganic.

Jeslic white, gave the symbolic interpretation of culture and noted that it is "extra-somatic means of adaptation through which man conveys his meanings"

He also gave following characteristics

- (i) Man cannot control or affect the course of culture. It is a PASSIVE participant in cultural propagation
- (ii) Culture cannot be analysed by human laws because it is above the human

CRITICISM

- (i) Reduced role of humans in affecting culture was criticised
- (ii) Edward Sapir called man an active element of culture
- (iii) Ruth Benedict in Patteris of culture (1934) highlighted that culture is "Personality not large" i.e. personality does affect culture.

(N) such view can be misused to
justify human rights violations as part of
cultural practice

e.g. Genital mutilation in Somalia; women

Supraorganic view of culture has lost
its relevance due to proof of interdependence
of man and his culture. Cultures must
not be allowed to continue violations
of rights in name of cultural relativism.

Marks:

Comment:

Intro:

Body:

Conclusion:

Total:

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